The Day the Voices Stopped

By Ken Steele

KEN: **(Pg 1-2)** The voices arrived without warning on an October night in 1962. I was 14 years old.

VOICE 1: ***Kill yourself. . . Set yourself afire***

KEN: I stirred, thinking I was having a nightmare, but I wasn't asleep; and the voices -- low and insistent, taunting and ridiculing --continued to speak to me from the radio.

VOICE 1: ***Hang yourself. The world will be better off. You're no good, no good at all.***

KEN: Terrified, I turned off the radio, got out of bed, and crept down the hallway in my bare feet. But the voices would not be tuned out. They accompanied me.

VOICE 1: ***You should die.***

VOICE 2: *(shrieking)* ***You should never have been born!***

KEN: They were talking to me. . . someone or something wanted ***me*** to die. Who was doing the talking? What was going on? I turned the handle to the door of my parents' bedroom, looking for safety, but my mom and dad were sleeping soundly, and I was afraid to wake them. I knew they had to go to work in the morning. And even if I woke them, what would I say? The voices supplied an answer.

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VOICE 1: ***Go right in! Tell your dad you're afraid of the dark and then tell him about us. It will only confirm what he already knows -- that you're different, a disappointment.***

KEN: The voices were right: This was not a man to whom I could confide that I was hearing things.

INTRODUCTION

For thirty-two years Ken Steele lived with the devastating symptoms of schizophrenia. The voices arrived without warning on an October night in 1962 when Ken was 14 years old. Derisive voices that continually said derogatory things to and about him. For thirty-two years, destructive voices inhabited his disordered mind, teasing him, mocking him, driving him time and again to the very edge of life. . . and daring him to take the final step. They commanded he kill himself in horrific ways. This is how Ken's story began . . . The Day the Voices Stopped by Ken Steele

KEN: **(Pg 2-5)** I wandered down the stairs of our tidy Cape Cod-style house to my grandmother's bedroom. Emma Mae, my mother's mother, was my best friend. I could tell her anything and she would still love me. As I turned

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the knob to her room, the voices in my head grew shriller and louder until I felt I was drowning in sound.

VOICE 2: ***Die, die, die. You're worthless, no good. Do it now, not later!***

KEN: I staggered into the living room and collapsed on the floor. My mother found me lying there in the morning. "What are you doing up so early?" she asked, shaking my shoulder. I remember thinking that my mother had arrived, like a lifeguard, to rescue me. Nw I was safe. But my relief was short-lived. The voices were still there, lower in volume and chattering in the singsong cadence that children use to taunt one another.

VOICE 1: ***Na na na na na / We're still he-ere / You thought you got rid of us / No such lu-uck.***

KEN: I felt bombarded by the noise and terrified by the strangeness of what was happening. *Act normal,* I told myself. I washed and dressed hurriedly. I went down to breakfast and forced myself to eat. My parents soon left for work, and, as she did every morning, Grandma let me television before I left for school. As I sat in front of the TV, all these people began to talk about me.

NEWSCASTER: ***Today, Kenny Steele will kill himself.***

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KEN: An electric shock ran through my body. Had I heard right? *(uses remote to change the channel)* Seconds later, Hugh Downs spoke to me

HUGH DOWNS: *(deeper voice)* ***Don't kill yourself, Kenny. Don't give up. Try not to do it.***

KEN: Barbara Walters conducted a posthumous interview with me.

BARBARA WALTERS: ***Why did you kill yourself?*** **she asked.** ***Did you really mean to do it?***

KEN: I raced out the door. The voices were screaming at me.

VOICE 2: ***Run, run, run, you coward!***

KEN: I turned right and ran past the school building but did not go in. Instead, I headed for the forest next to the school. I hoped to hide from the voices among the dense foliage, but they found me and continued their diatribe.

VOICE 1: ***You're worthless. . .***

VOICE 2: ***Your parents don't want you around anymore. . .***

VOICE 1: ***You could leave home. . .***

VOICE 2: ***Better yet, you could kill yourself. . .***

VOICE 1: ***Yes, that's it. That's the answer. . . Die.***

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KEN: *(defeated)* I don't know how long I lingered in the forest that day. *(long beat)* A couple of weeks later, Dad came home from work excited.

DAD: The president will be speaking about the Cuban missile crisis tonight. I want you to hear what he has to say about the Communists.

KEN: As President Kennedy spoke to the nation, ***my*** voices spewed obscenities at me. It was impossible for me to hear and understand what was being said. The President concluded his talk, and Dad began to speak to me.

DAD: What are they teaching you in school

VOICE 2: ***Don't listen to your father. He's no good*.**

DAD: about Khruschev and Cuba and about those

VOICE 1: ***Don't answer his questions. . .***

DAD: terrible Communists and their plan to ravage the world?

VOICE 2: ***Turn your back on him! Turn away now!***

KEN: **(Pg 6-8)** That evening, the voices won out. As my father quizzed me about what we had seen on TV, what I knew, what I thought, I did as the voices directed *(overwhelmed, puts hands over ears and turns away)*

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Dad became enraged. "Go to bed without dinner," he ordered me, stalking out of the living room. It was a punishment he rarely imposed.

VOICE 1: ***Ungrateful boy,* now *see what you've done.***

VOICE 2: ***You've disappointed your father [again]. Your parents deserve a better son than you.***

KEN: Soon they would have one. Some time after the voices first visited me, my mother and father told me they were expecting a baby. *If I have to have a sibling,* I prayed, *let it be a sister.* But the voices knew better. They had decided the baby would be a boy, and on several terrifying occasions they made it seem as if "he" were speaking to me.

BABY BROTHER: *(whispering menacingly) I am coming, I'm going to be born. You have to leave. Take a radio into the bathtub and electrocute yourself . . . Jump in front of a car at night on Route 69. . . Pour charcoal lighter fluid over your body and set yourself afire. . . Hang yourself in the forest.*

KEN: My brother was born May 10, 1964 – Joseph Robert Steele.

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VOICE 1: ***He's here now*** *(laughing maniacally)* ***Joey is the good son. He's the one they wanted.***

VOICE 2: ***It's time for you to go . . . Stop hanging around.***

KEN: Only two things, reading and writing, could tone the voices down. When I read, I entered the world of Huckleberry Finn; I'd suffer the growing pains of Holden Caulfield. The voices would become muffled. And so I read voraciously. I read my way through the last year of junior high school and wrote frantically, scribbling page after page before the voices took over. For three years, I managed to cover up what was happening to me, or so I thought.

(Pg 9-12) But the voices were stepping up their demands that I destroy myself.

VOICE 1: ***No simple death for you! Guts and gore and a big mess. . . that's the way you must take your life.***

VOICE 2: ***Get out that door. . . Run, run, run. You've got to die.***

KEN: And so I ran away from home. I ran to the same forest in which I had sought refuge the first time the voices had descended on me.

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VOICE 1: ***Get a rope, twelve feet long and two inches thick.***

KEN: I'd gone to a hardware store and bought the rope.

VOICE 2: ***Tie the noose with a sea knot, and make sure it's tied tight***

KEN: I practiced tying knots. At the direction of the voices, I had also taken a step stool from the basement and hidden it in the forest, covering it over with branches and leaves. I'd bought lighter fluid and matches and left them in a small locker that I'd hidden in the same area. When all the preparations had been made, the voices were pleased with me.

VOICE 1: ***Good, your suicide kit is complete.***

KEN: That night -- the night I ran away -- I made three different attempts on my life. First, I got up on the stool, then tied the noose around my neck. But even though I tossed and thrashed about, I couldn't manage to kick the stool away. I had failed. Tears streaming down my face, I located the charcoal lighter fluid and poured it on my head. I could not bring myself to light a match. ***The highway,*** I thought, half running, half dragging myself in my disoriented state about a mile to

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Route 69. My plan was to leap in front of a car. I stood at the side of the road. Headlights were coming at me. ***Now!*** I told myself, but then I noticed a spotlight atop the car. What if this was a police car? What if the police were coming for me? Panicked, I ran back from the road, back toward the school that sat dark and deserted in the summer night. I crouched behind the building, clinging to its hard concrete walls for what seemed like eternity.

The following morning, I rose and headed for home. Two state trooper cars were parked outside our house. Dad stood in our front yard, talking animatedly with the troopers. I froze in my tracks. My dad turned and saw me.

VOICE 2: ***They're going to shoot you. See the guns in their holsters? Your dad is arranging to have you killed.***

KEN: My parents had called the troopers, reporting me as a runaway who had threatened suicide. Now the officers wanted to escort me to the hospital. Dad convinced them to let him take me to our family physician, Dr. Sullivan, instead. It was growing dark and pouring when we drove to the appointment. Dr. Sullivan asked if he

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could speak with me alone. I have no memory of what the doctor said or did, but I clearly recall the looks of worry and confusion on my parents' faces when the doctor called them back in.

Mom, Dad, and I returned home. Later that night, I heard my father speaking on the telephone. He was talking about me. He was telling the person on the other end that I had a very serious mental illness. It had a long name, and I remember wanting to know how to spell it. That way, I could look it up in the library and learn how to get rid of the voices..

I walked over to my dad and asked him if he would spell the disease. Dad leaned his forehead into his hand and handed me a small slip of paper. On it, there was one word, neatly printed in capital letters: *(begins spelling aloud)* **S C H I Z O . . .**

VOICE 2: *(interrupting)* ***Schizo – Schizo - Schizophrenia!*** *(laughter)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ken Steele
ISBN: May 2002
Publisher: Basic Books
Date (Month/Year): 978-0465082278

AWARD HISTORY

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NIETOC
World IE Championship
KS State Qualifier

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